NO. 146 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

WEDNESDAY 28 OCTOBER 2026



SEVENTY-SEVEN PER CENT VOTED. NOTHING HAS BEEN COUNTED (P3)

TECHNOLOGY

Anthropic files to list, and states its compute bill as a dollar sign with no number

THE RABBIT HOLE

The darkroom, where €2,666 of electronics bolts onto a €149 enlarger

THE LONG READ

Australia banned the card fee; the rails that take rent stopped taking cards

Source: David Goldman / Associated Press, via Al Jazeera. Voters at a polling station in Tel Aviv, 27 October 2026.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 146

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A STRAIGHT NEWS BOOK. No spine is forced on this edition. One thing did recur without being looked for: on p7 a company states its revenue to the dollar and its largest obligation as a blank; on p9 a maker publishes everything but the figure that would test the product; on p3 a record turnout stands in for a result nobody has counted. Make of it what you like. The Long Read is about one country and one rule.

FROM THE DESK

"People of the same trade seldom meet together, even for merriment and diversion, but the conversation ends in a conspiracy against the public, or in some contrivance to raise prices."

Adam Smith, *An Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of the Wealth of Nations*, Book I, Chapter X, 1776[1]

Usually quoted against cartels. It earns its place here as a remark about where a price comes from — not from a rule, but from whoever can write one down (p21).

THE STRIP · AT TUESDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.99%	▼ 1bp
10-yr real[2]	2.64%	▼ 2bp
VWRA	$191.30	▲ 0.63%
AGGU	$5.80	▼ 0.07%
Brent	$114.22	▼ 1.37%
Gold	$4,060.08	▲ 1.08%
Bitcoin	$80,655	▲ 0.81%
USD/SGD	1.2812	—
STI	5,397.03	▼ 0.35%

The ten-year is 4.99 and 2.64 of it real. The subtraction is this magazine's own, of two curves the Treasury publishes separately (p14). Not advice.[2]

SIX NUMBERS FROM THIS ISSUE

Six hundred and fifty thousand. Double-envelope ballots in Israel still to be opened one name at a time — enough to invert a two-seat story (p3).

Four times. A prospectus states its aggregate compute commitment as "more than $ ", with the figure left out, in four separate places (p7).

Fifty-five cents. The average rise at the Australian cafés that raised prices when a surcharge of about six and a half cents was abolished (p21).

Fifty-seven hours a week. The average play of the heaviest-gaming quarter of a Singapore schools cohort — whose hours did not predict their symptoms (p12).

Two thousand six hundred and sixty-six euros. Of electronics that bolt onto a one-hundred-and-forty-nine-euro enlarger (p16).

Zero of twenty-six. Positive notices for a twenty-million-dollar adaptation that took a Sunday average of one hundred and ninety-eight dollars a screen (p11).

SOURCES 1 Adam Smith, *An Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of the Wealth of Nations* (1776), Book I, Chapter X, Part II, as the passage is printed in the standard editions. 2 Levels at Tuesday's close, each read at its own source and sourced individually on p14, where the real yield and the breakeven are derived from the two Treasury curves.

THE WORLD · ISRAEL'S ELECTION

Israel's record turnout leaves neither Netanyahu nor Eisenkot a majority

Exit polls put Netanyahu's bloc on 50 seats and Gadi Eisenkot's on 52 to 53, with Arab parties at a record 17 — and not one ballot had been counted when this page was set.

Israelis voted on Tuesday for all **120** seats of the Knesset, and at 22:00 the Central Elections Committee put turnout at **77 per cent** — the highest since **1999**, about **7.1 points** above the same hour in 2022. **7,331,981** voters were registered across **12,018** stations, choosing between **36** lists against a 3.25 per cent threshold.[1]

Turnout was the only counted number of the night. Kan 11, Channel 12 and Reshet 13 agreed on the shape: **Benjamin Netanyahu**'s bloc at **50**, the opposition bloc led by **Gadi Eisenkot** at **52 to 53**, the Arab parties at **17 to 18** against the **10** they hold. Sixty-one is a majority. Nobody has it, and the only arithmetic that reaches it runs through parties no Jewish-majority bloc will publicly sit with.[2]

Counting began as the stations shut. More than **650,000** "double-envelope" ballots — soldiers, diplomats, hospital patients, displaced residents — must each be verified by the name on an outer envelope before the anonymous inner ballot joins the pile. Acting Director-General **Dean Livne** warned the volume could push completion to **Friday morning**. The law requires official results by **4 November**; the Knesset convenes on the **10th**.[3]

Those ballots lean right, and a net swing of two or three seats is the whole difference between the headline above and its opposite. Military turnout passed **68 per cent** by 17:00; the diplomatic missions voted at **86**. No exit poll can see any of them.[4]

> ***"Eisenkot can win, but he cannot govern without an Arab party in his coalition."***

JERUSALEM — TIMES OF ISRAEL

Carries the winners at full volume. Eisenkot: "a complete vote of no confidence in Netanyahu and the October 7 government". **Yair Lapid**: the bloc "has suffered a crushing defeat". Foreign Minister **Gideon Sa'ar**, on the same page, calls the celebration "premature".[2]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Reports a referendum that returned nothing: exit polls after "what many pundits and voters have billed as the most pivotal election in Israel's history" indicate no clear winner. The frame is 7 October 2023 and the wars, not the coalition arithmetic.[5]

NAZARETH — THE ARAB LISTS

Mansour Abbas (Ra'am) called Netanyahu's election-day posts a "scare tactic", then: "We'll translate this electoral power into an influential political force." Netanyahu had written on X that Arab voters were "raiding the polling stations".[6]

TEHRAN — GLOBAL TIMES, CARRYING XINHUA

Headlines Iran's indifference. Spokesman **Esmaeil Baghaei**, Monday: Israel's record has brought the region only "violence and massacre", and on talk of a strike to disrupt the vote, that Israel is "highly adept at carrying out false-flag operations".[7]

THE CHATTER · FIVE EXIT POLLS, TWO ELECTIONS

The spread is the artefact. Three broadcasters land near 50–53. **Channel 14**, openly pro-Netanyahu, printed **60–43** to the coalition. Haaretz explains why without taking a side: Channels 11 to 13 sampled "a few dozen polling stations", 14 and 15 ran a much larger survey. A second conflict is unresolved — Haaretz's table gives i24's Likud at **19**, i24's own poll says **27**.

THE SCEPTIC · A WINNING BLOC THAT CANNOT GOVERN

Joseph Mansour, once an aide to MK Ayman Odeh, wrote the hard version in July, before a vote was cast. The constraint he cites is the Democracy Index: **seventy per cent** of Jewish Israelis oppose including an Arab party in government. **Avigdor Liberman refuses to serve alongside them; Naftali Bennett has ruled out relying on them.** So 52 to 53 may not be a governing bloc at all.

650,000

DOUBLE-ENVELOPE BALLOTS STILL TO BE OPENED ONE NAME AT A TIME — ENOUGH TO INVERT A TWO-SEAT STORY[3]

SOURCES 1 Committee turnout ladder as NBC News and Haaretz carry it, both read in full; registered voters, stations and lists from Xinhua's Jerusalem dateline of 27 October. **The committee's own portal serves no text to anything but a browser, so nothing here is read at the committee.**

THE WORLD · JORDAN STRIKES SYRIA

Jordan bombs southern Syria; Damascus calls the strike “treacherous”

Amman says it killed more than 20 Islamic State fighters in coordination with Damascus after a church-funeral massacre killed nine at Karak; Syria counts seven civilian dead, including three children, and says it was never told.

Jordan’s air force struck four sites in rural Deraa and Suwayda overnight on 26–27 October, three days after three gunmen opened fire on mourners at a Greek Orthodox funeral in Karak, ninety kilometres south of Amman, killing nine. ISIL claimed the attack. Government spokesman Mohammad al-Momani said the strikes killed more than 20 Islamic State fighters and that the operation was “conducted in coordination with Damascus”.[1]

Syrian customs then shut the Nassib crossing in both directions — the only road between the two countries. King Abdullah II had ordered an “iron fist”; three men were detained at Al-Jadeeda on Monday after a three-hour firefight.[1]

ALSO THIS WEEK

DR Congo’s Ebola outbreak passes 10,000. Health ministry data released Tuesday put the Bundibugyo outbreak at 10,060 confirmed cases and 4,887 deaths across 66 health zones in eight provinces — the country’s deadliest, and the second-largest on record. **About 80 per cent of new cases come from outside monitored transmission chains**, where Africa CDC’s control threshold is 95 per cent inside them. WHO began the first clinical trial of a Bundibugyo vaccine on 23 October.[2]

Serbia’s students won, then walked into a newsroom. With 98.71 per cent counted, the Student List has 53.50 per cent against 39.64 for Aleksandar Vučić–United Serbia. Vučić conceded on election night, ending fourteen years. On Monday about 30 protesters entered the newsroom of Informer TV and surrounded owner Dragan Vučičević, who broadcast it live: “They have said everything about themselves, and nothing about us.” **The 141-to-103 seat split everyone is quoting is a CeSID–Ipsos projection, not an allocation.**[3]

Brasília, the delta. Still no certification — and Senator Flávio Bolsonaro flew to the United States on 27 October, a day after being ordered to surrender his passports. The government then cancelled them.[4]

THE CHATTER · THIRTEEN OUTLETS, ONE CLOSURE

Before the vote on p3, Israel sealed every West Bank crossing. A media monitor logged thirteen outlets on the one decision. Al Jazeera Net: “Israel turns the West Bank into a big prison before the day of the elections.” Euronews: “Israel orders the closure of the West Bank during the elections.” Times of Israel: “IDF to impose lockdown on West Bank during Israel’s election.” Same order; three sentences about who did what to whom.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE BEREAVED DISPUTE THE TARGETING

Al Jazeera’s 27 October report is headlined “Families of victims killed in Jordanian strike deny links to church attack”, and a funeral was held the same day. Jordan had not answered the civilian-casualty claims when that went out. Amman has struck inside Syria since 2023 against smugglers, and those strikes killed women and children in January 2024, which Human Rights Watch said required accountability. The two accounts cannot both be true on the one fact that decides the law: whether Damascus consented.[6]

4,887

EBOLA DEATHS IN DR CONGO AGAINST 10,060 CONFIRMED CASES — AND AT LEAST HALF OF THOSE WHO DIED WERE NEVER ADMITTED FOR TREATMENT[2]

Held from No. 145. The West Bank crossings are still not confirmed reopened: the army said they would reopen after election day, “likely Wednesday morning, pending a fresh assessment”, and that remains the army’s word. Hebron Municipality now counts 488 families and about 3,171 people displaced, against Defence Minister Israel Katz’s “about 2,000” and the mayor’s 2,200. The story went dark the moment the polls opened: none of the election copy this desk read mentions the crossings at all.[7]

SOURCES 1 Al Jazeera’s explainer and strike report, both read in full; corroborated independently by Reuters out of Amman, 27 October.

SINGAPORE · THE RETIREMENT AGE

The retirement age in Singapore moves to 65 in January 2029

The Tripartite Workgroup's six recommendations, all accepted by Government on 26 October, also lift re-employment to 70 and replace the Senior Employment Credit with a Re-Employment Credit paying up to 7 per cent of wages.

A tripartite workgroup co-chaired by NTUC, the Ministry of Manpower and the employers' federation reported on 26 October, and the Government accepted all six of its recommendations the same day. The headline one moves the statutory retirement age from 64 to 65 and the re-employment age from 69 to 70 on 1 January 2029 — a full year ahead of the 2030 date the previous workgroup set in 2019.[1]

The ladder is the thing to read. 62 and 67 in July 2017; 63 and 68 in 2022; 64 and 69 this July; 65 and 70 in January 2029. Each step has been about a year of working life added every three, and the workgroup has now bought a year back from the schedule.[1]

Behind it are two numbers moving in opposite directions. Labour-force participation among residents aged 60 to 69 rose from 53.8 per cent in 2015 to 59.6 in 2025; those aged 50 and over went from 34.1 per cent of the resident labour force to 39.9. Against that, citizens aged 65 and over go from 20.7 per cent of the population now to 23.9 by 2030. Participation is rising and the denominator is rising faster.[2]

> *"Growing older should not mean being written off, or having assumptions made about one's ability."*

THE CHATTER · THE FORUMS WERE ARGUING ABOUT SMOKE

Singapore's own boards had almost nothing to say about 65 and 70 this week; the live thread was the haze task force announced in Jakarta. IamTed: "More like a performance for the domestic audiences from both sides." weekaykee: "All wayang.

THE SCEPTIC · THE NUMBER IS IN THE GOVERNMENT'S OWN REPORT

No named economist criticised the move this week, and this desk went looking. The sharpest counterweight is inside the workgroup's own document, sourced to the employers' federation: in a January 2026 poll of 165 employers, 59 per cent said higher insurance premiums add to cost pressure and 47 per cent said medical-benefit costs influence whether they hire or retain a senior worker.

7.6%

PART-TIME EMPLOYMENT AMONG SINGAPORE RESIDENTS AGED 55 TO 64 IN 2025, AGAINST AN OECD AVERAGE OF 10.2 — THE GAP THE NEW FLEXI-LOAD PROGRAMME IS AIMED AT[2]

ALSO ON THIS DESK

Ten companies served notice over the haze. On 23 October ten Singapore-registered palm oil and forestry companies with Indonesian concessions were served under Section 10 of the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act. On the 27th, Singapore and Indonesia announced a joint task force on the money behind the fires. Indonesian Foreign Minister Arrmanatha Nasir: "smoke can cross borders, so can money." Single-sourced on the ten notices.[3]

Saudi crude into the rock caverns. Minister Tan See Leng told the Singapore Energy Lecture on 26 October that Saudi crude will be stored in the Jurong Rock Caverns from the second half of 2027. On the Indonesian pipeline cut: the reduction is "less than 2 per cent of our total daily gas demand". Generation capacity is to grow 26 per cent from about 12GW.[4]

110,000 records at Alliance Medinet. Names, identification numbers, birth dates and policy details were compromised; seven members' bank details and one member's diagnosis may have been. PDPC is investigating. One outlet; no company filing read.[5]

SOURCES 1 The Ministry of Manpower's release of 26 October and the workgroup's own report, whose text was extracted and read here; the statutory ladder is its Figure F. 2 Participation, ageing and part-time figures are the report's own. 3 The report's Box Story 12, citing the employers' federation's January 2026 poll. 4 HardwareZone, 27 October, by handle; Reddit is unreachable from this desk. 5 A Straits Times report via AsiaOne and a ministry transcript, both 26–27 October — single-outlet where said.

THE ATELIER · TABLE LINEN

Ferguson's of Banbridge says no other house still weaves double damask

A 175cm loom width caps every tablecloth the serious mills make, thread counts top out near 202 rather than 1,000, and Matouk's US$550 linen cloth is sewn in the Philippines from Italian fabric.

Start with the number that is not there. Almost nobody publishes a thread count for a linen tablecloth; the houses that do publish honest ones. Ferguson's Irish Linen of Banbridge, weaving since 1854, makes what a long-established retailer describes as a 160-count damask and a 202-count double damask. Any cloth advertised in the high hundreds is counting something else.[1]

The fibre comes from a narrow belt: the trade body for European flax puts three-quarters of world production in a coastal strip from Brittany to the Netherlands, and the whole crop is under 0.5 per cent of world textile fibre. Where it is spun is another matter. The certifier's own directory of 3,081 companies lists 1,387 in China, against 105 in Belgium and 72 in France — and Libeco, a Belgian weaver, says plainly that "more than 90 per cent of our yarn is purchased in European spinning mills". It weaves; it does not spin. Hackling splits the crop before any of that: the long combed line goes to fine cloth, the short tow to coarse yarn.[2]

> *"Double damask is something that only we at Ferguson's Irish Linen weave."*

WHAT FOUR NAPKINS COST, UP THE LADDER

€39.60 — Garnier-Thiebaut cotton, Gérardmer. €71.60 — Lapuan Kankurit Venla, the one house publishing Masters of Linen yarn, its own mill, its own finishing plant and the sewing town on one page. £92 — Ferguson's single damask. £168 — Ferguson's double damask. €368 — Once Milano Sicily lace. A 9.3× spread, all read on one day.[3]

The sweet spot is £337. Ferguson's Smooth Sateen damask cloth at £245, woven in Ireland with a standard 5mm hem, plus four napkins at £23. The grail is the same house at £520–£688 for double damask in lengths to 595cm. And a 19th-century Napoleon III damask cloth with nine monogrammed napkins, washed and starched, is €95 from a dealer in Tourrettes.[3]

THE CHATTER · THEY STILL IRON, AND THEY IRON DAMP

The doctrine is consistent across years of forum threads. lana_roma: linens "should be ironed while damp with an iron on the hottest setting" and "I do not use the steam function." Rebecca Hicks supplies the buy-once datum: "The night before I washed and ironed 40 vintage linen napkins... These were my grandmother's from the 1930's." And linnea56 mourns the machine nobody has any more: "My Mom had a mangle... It takes a really long time on an ironing board."[4]

THE SCEPTIC · "BELGIAN LINEN" IS A WEAVING ADDRESS

The label's own site states its two rules: the fabric "must be woven in a Belgium based mill", and "at least 85 per cent of the weight... must consist of flax grown in the EU". The flax need not be Belgian and the cloth need not be all linen. Libeco's Riverside reads like the budget Belgian entry at US$223 — and is 60 per cent linen, 40 per cent polyester.

150–175cm

THE LOOM WIDTH AT EVERY SERIOUS MILL IN THIS CATEGORY — THE ONE DIMENSION A TABLECLOTH CANNOT BUY ITS WAY OUT OF[1]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Cast-iron kettles — Nambu ironware, the iron-water claim, and the makers left in Iwate.

Mosquito nets — mesh counts, denier, and the treated nets the WHO lists.

Brooms & brushes — horsehair, tampico and beech, and who still drills the stock.

Singapore. Linen is right for the climate and wrong for the cupboard: it is the folds that fail, not the cloth. Roll long cloths on a tube, store them out of plastic. Locally, Ong Shunmugam sells a French-flax cloth made in Singapore for a six-seat table at S$119.[5]

SOURCES 1 Ferguson's Irish Linen's own collection and product pages, read 27 October, where the 175cm width, the 5mm hem and "Woven IN IRELAND" appear on each cloth; the 160 and 202 thread counts are a retailer's. 2 The European flax trade body's own pages and certified-companies directory; Libeco's own account of yarn, retting and hackling. 3 Prices read at each maker's storefront on 27 October. 4 Houzz, by handle — that site serves only the opening post and the featured answer to this desk, and Reddit refused it entirely. 5 The Belgian Linen label's own rules page, Libeco's composition at a US retailer, and Matouk's own product page.

TECHNOLOGY · ANTHROPIC'S PROSPECTUS

Anthropic files to list on Nasdaq, compute bill left blank

The S-1 of 26 October gives first-half revenue as US$16.3bn and states the aggregate compute commitment four times as "more than $ " — and leaves the third-quarter revenue figure blank in three places too.

Anthropic, PBC filed a Form S-1 with the Securities and Exchange Commission on 26 October, file number 333-299633, naming Nasdaq and the ticker ANT. No amendment had been filed by Wednesday morning in Singapore, so the held question from No. 145 is answered: the figure is still missing.[1]

The audited footnotes do carry numbers, and they do not reconcile. Non-cancelable contractual commitments total $54.6bn. Expected future fixed or minimum guaranteed commitments at 30 June were about $265.6bn. Leases not yet commenced went from $50.2bn at the end of December to $321.4bn six months later. Agreements entered after 30 June add about $245bn, short-term ones about $21bn, and unfinalised capacity for 2028 to 2031 a further $125bn to $150bn that the filing says is excluded from the table. Six outlets have published six different totals, from $417bn to about a trillion, because the only authoritative one is the blank.[2]

The counterparties are named and the structure is identical each time: a floor, payable whether used or not. Microsoft, at least $44.9bn to May 2033. Google, at least $114.5bn to July 2033. Amazon, at least $110.0bn to April 2036. Broadcom's equipment lease, about $125.2bn excluding interest over five years. And SpaceXAI — formerly X.AI, now a wholly-owned SpaceX subsidiary — up to $120.5bn, about $3.1bn a month once capacity lands in December. That last one is 90 days' notice from evaporating: after initial non-cancelable periods ending in January and March 2027, either party may cancel.[1]

"The one schedule no valuation can do without is the one it has chosen to file last."

THE CHATTER · 1,684 POINTS, ARGUING ABOUT THE LOSS

The Hacker News thread ran to 1,684 points and 1,641 comments. The headline loss of $80.7bn for the half is mostly a revaluation: $72.4bn of it is the change in fair value of convertible notes and similar instruments, driven by the company's own rising valuation.

THE SCEPTIC · NOT CONCEALMENT, SHE ARGUES — INADEQUACY

Raphaëlle d'Ornano confirms the blanks independently and then refuses the obvious reading: "That is not concealment so much as a sign that the instruments have not caught up." Her own reconstruction stacks $265.6bn and $321.4bn into about $587bn at 30 June, then adds the post-June and short-term tranches to roughly $853bn, which she labels an unreconciled gross subtotal, and warns that the named counterparty figures are not additive to the filed totals. Her near-trillion is an estimate and says so.

Four times

THE COMPUTE COMMITMENT IS STATED AS A DOLLAR SIGN WITH NO NUMBER — SUMMARY, RISK FACTORS TWICE, AND THE DISCUSSION OF RESULTS[1]

One sovereignty line belongs in the record, and it is the filing's own. In June 2026 the Department of Commerce "imposed worldwide export restrictions" on two of the company's models, which it disabled for all customers until the restrictions were lifted after safeguards were updated. A United States export control, exercised against the weights of a United States laboratory, disclosed by the laboratory in its own prospectus.[1]

SOURCES 1 The registration statement itself, downloaded in full from the Commission's own archive and searched here; every phrase in quotation marks above is verbatim from that document, blanks included. EDGAR shows one filing for the company and no amendment as of this edition.

THE HOME LAB · LIQUID AI'S LFM3

Liquid AI ships six open models on one 1.7-billion-parameter backbone

LFM3 launched on 27 October with a 256,000-token context and a quantised file of 0.98 GiB; llama.cpp merged support the same day, and the licence stops at US$10m of revenue.

Liquid AI released LFM3 on 27 October: six open-weight models built on one 1.73-billion-parameter backbone — text, vision, audio, an omni variant and two distilled siblings. The architecture is the interesting part. Twenty-four layers in a tri-hybrid pattern: 13 gated short convolutions, 6 full-attention grouped-query layers, 5 sliding-window. Vocabulary 128,000; context 256K, pre-trained on 22 trillion tokens with a final 3.5 trillion spent extending the window.[1]

The file sizes are what decide whether it runs on your desk, and they are published. BF16 is 3.23 GiB; Q8_0 1.72; Q4_K_M 1.02; and the quantisation-aware QAD-Q4_0 is 0.98 GiB, the smallest in the repository and the one Liquid benchmarks. Budget for more than that in practice: the KV cache for a 128K context is 1.6GB on its own.[1]

Liquid's own measurements, run through llama.cpp at Q4_0 on 32K of input, give 129.6 generation tokens a second on an AMD Ryzen AI Max+ 395 at a 2.75GB footprint, 237.1 on an Apple M5 Max at 2.25GB, and 43.6 on an iPhone 17 Pro at 1.90GB. The company claims 1.8× to 2.8× the next-fastest model in each comparison. It is also candid in its own model card that this is "not recommended for agentic coding or complex multi-step reasoning due to its small size", and it loses to a 9-billion-parameter rival on four benchmarks of eight.[1]

> *"Every cross-vendor row in this comparison is a coin flip dressed as a measurement."*

THE MERGE WORTH HAVING THIS WEEK

llama.cpp PR 21231 — `--models-memory-margin`. The server router now tracks each model's projected memory per device and unloads the least-recently-used model rather than overcommitting. The author's worked case is a DGX Spark with about 120GB shared: an embedding model at 6.7GB, a 35B at Q6_K at 38.7GB and a 122B at Q4_K_M at 82.8GB need about 124GB together, which previously threw an out-of-memory error and froze the machine. Merged 27 October.[2]

Also merged, 25–27 October: a Metal top-k mask operator and a core change decoupling sparse k-pool selection from the mask shape, landing the same day; a Qwen-family attention rework; a Hexagon matrix-multiply optimisation whose title promises a speed-up and whose page publishes no number; and a small command-line change making `--model` or `-hf` mandatory, which will break scripts.[2]

THE CORRECTION · THIS MAGAZINE HAD THE WRONG ISSUE NUMBER

No. 145 reported a prefix-cache corruption as vLLM issue 30944. That number is a merged feature pull request for on-the-fly quantisation and has nothing to do with it. The corruption is vLLM issue 55766, and it is still open — no labels, no assignee, no linked fix, no maintainer comment in seven weeks, last activity 24 October.

THE SCEPTIC · A 23–4 SCOREBOARD ONE VENDOR BUILT

Rowan Sterling of OrcaRouter takes Liquid's comparison table apart without taking the other model's side. The receipt is specific: on one function-calling benchmark Liquid measures its rival at 62.65 where that rival's own publisher reports 66.6, and on a software-engineering benchmark the two vendors' numbers favour opposite models.

0.98 GiB

THE QUANTISATION-AWARE FOUR-BIT LFM3 FILE — THE WEIGHTS ONLY; A 128K CONTEXT ADDS 1.6GB OF CACHE[1]

The workarounds, for anyone hitting 55766 today, come from the reporters rather than the maintainers: force piecewise graph compilation, switch to the second-generation model runner, or run eager. One reproduction is on four RTX 4090s, another on a single 3090 — 58 of 60 requests wrong when the prefill tail was exactly four tokens, 37 of them not-a-number, while tails of three, five and nine were clean.[3]

SOURCES 1 Liquid AI's model card and technical write-up, read at source; file sizes read from the repository's own blob listing in bytes and converted here; the performance figures are Liquid's own, as reported in launch coverage, and are the vendor's measurements, not an independent test.

THE KIT · OPEN-EAR BUDS

Samsung's Galaxy Buds On reach Korea at 299,000 won

Samsung's first clip-on open-ear bud went on sale on 27 October with 9.5 hours of playback and no published water rating — and two outlets are already printing an IP54 figure Samsung never gave.

Samsung began selling the Galaxy Buds On in South Korea on 27 October at 299,000 won, in black only — its first open-ear, clip-on design. Each bud carries an 11.3mm driver on a Qualcomm S7 Gen 1 platform with a Class-D amplifier, three microphones and a bone-conduction voice sensor, and Samsung claims 9.5 hours of playback and 38 with the case. A global rollout is promised with no market, date or price attached, and no Singapore price exists.[1]

What Samsung does not publish is the more useful list. There is no water or dust rating, no Bluetooth version, no codec list, no weight, no case capacity and no driver specification beyond the millimetre figure. That is a lot of blanks for a bud at roughly two hundred and twenty US dollars.[1]

And the gap has already been filled by someone else. At least two technology sites now report the Buds On as IP54. Samsung has published no such rating anywhere this desk could read. A specification the maker never gave is circulating as a fact within a day of launch, which is the kind of thing this column exists to catch.[1]

> *"Both male and female vocals have a strange hollowness to them, sometimes placing them behind the instruments."*

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Audio-Technica ATH-AWX7000 — the held price question, answered. The No. 145 note held a €3,799-against-$3,799 discrepancy open. **It is not an error.** The headphone is US$3,799, €3,799 and £3,299, so a European buyer pays roughly **9 to 10 per cent** more than an American for the same object and a British buyer pays less than both. Kiso cypress cups in Echizen lacquer, deerskin pads, **58mm** driver, **48 ohms**, **353g**, built in Tokyo. **No Singapore price. No distortion figure published. And still nobody has measured it** — the only verdicts in print are two reviewers' ears.[2]

Nothing Headphone (1) Pro reaches Singapore at S$549. Pre-orders are live on Nothing's own Singapore store against **US$399** elsewhere — about a **5 per cent** premium, the opposite of the Audio-Technica. Three drivers a side including a solid-state treble unit, **Bluetooth 6.1**, LDAC, IP52, **327g**. **The battery went backwards: 30 hours with cancellation on, against 35 on the model it replaces.** The store page shows "Sold Out" and "Pre-order" at once and gives no ship date.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE ONE VERDICT THAT EXISTS

On the Audio-Technica, Alex Schiffer at MajorHiFi is positive on bass, stage and craft and then says the quiet part: vocals have "a strange hollowness" and "consistently feel far away, never taking a commanding stance in the mix"; the upper treble produces "a glaring tone that might not be everybody's cup of tea". A second reviewer, at a New York retailer, found the bass "a bit overwhelming" for the bass-sensitive and the depth less than expected.

THE SCEPTIC · THREE LAUNCHES, NO MEASUREMENT BETWEEN THEM

The common thread on this page is not price, it is evidence. A US$3,799 flagship closed-back has shipped with no published distortion spec and no independent measurement. A 299,000-won open-ear bud has shipped with no water rating, no codec list and no reviews, and already has a borrowed IP number attached to it. A S$549 headphone publishes its specifications generously and then shows two contradictory stock states on its own storefront.

IP54

THE WATER RATING TWO OUTLETS HAVE ATTRIBUTED TO THE GALAXY BUDS ON. SAMSUNG HAS PUBLISHED NO RATING AT ALL[1]

SOURCES 1 Samsung's Korean launch as Notebookcheck and SamMobile report it, both read at source; Notebookcheck states plainly that driver specification, case capacity, weight, water rating, codecs and Bluetooth version are all undisclosed, and the IP54 figure appears at two other sites without a Samsung source. The leakage disclaimer is Samsung's own wording.

THE GOOD LIFE · BREITLING'S NAVITIMER

Breitling puts a hand-wound movement in the core Navitimer at S$10,450

The B09 Chronograph 41, launched on 22 October, is chronometer-certified with a 70-hour reserve — and is already on sale at six different public prices, two of which contradict each other inside one review.

Breitling launched the Navitimer B09 Chronograph 41 on 22 October and did something it has not done in the permanent collection: left out the rotor. The calibre B09 is manually wound, chronometer-certified, beats at 4Hz and runs 70 hours. The case is 41mm across and 13mm tall — thinner than the automatics — with the slide-rule bezel, a reverse-panda dial and no date. These are not limited editions.[1]

Singapore has a published price, which is rarer than it should be: S$10,450 for either of two references on Breitling's own Singapore site, both flagged new. The United States site lists six B09 references from US$7,900 on a strap to US$9,600 for the Miles Davis edition on a bracelet. European coverage gives €7,450 and £6,200 on strap.[1]

Then the prices stop agreeing. One watch title published the B09 at £6,750 and £7,150 in its body text and £6,200 and £6,500 in its own specification box, on the same page, on launch day — and gave the lug-to-lug as 47.9mm in one place and 47.09mm in the other. A Swiss franc figure is also in circulation that this desk could not read at source, and so is not printed here.[2]

The sibling is the context. The B02 Cosmonaute, the 24-hour Navitimer, sits at about €10,000, and the gap is what the comment threads argued about all week. The Miles Davis B09, launched a month earlier, is US$1,000 dearer than the identical standard reference.[1]

> *"Breitling lacks the secondary market value retention and ultimate brand equity to sustain those price tiers comfortably."*

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Lange price still does not exist. The No. 145 note held open the absence of any published price for a watch this desk covered then. Nothing has been published since. It stays held rather than estimated.

The Audio-Technica flagship is on p9, where it belongs: at US$3,799 it is a gear purchase, not an object of desire, until somebody measures it.

THE CHATTER · THEY ARGUED ABOUT THE MOVEMENT, NOT THE DIAL

The comment thread under one launch piece ran hot within hours, and almost none of it was about the dial. A_Padella, on the calibre you can see through the back: "IMHO the movement isn't nice at all. The overall aspect is quite messy." erranto: "And that's how to keep your brand uninteresting." MarkBu put the real question: "Not sure I understand the 2,500 euro price difference between the B09 and the B02." Flax took the other side: "I would definitely go for the B09 no matter what. The price even seems fair." And Sweetwater caught the omission: the Miles Davis version "costs €1500 more. For some reason, you don't even mention it???"[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A HAND-WOUND MOVEMENT IS A SUBTRACTION SOLD AS A FEATURE

Victor777 states the bear case without heat: Breitling "lacks the secondary market value retention and ultimate brand equity to sustain those price tiers comfortably." The structural version is simpler. Removing the automatic winding removes parts and adds a daily chore, and the result costs about the same as the automatic it sits beside — the premium is for thinness and for the view through the back. That is a legitimate thing to want and a strange thing to be charged for, and the six-price spread suggests nobody has settled what it is worth. The dated test: whether a Singapore grey-market discount appears before the end of the year.[4]

70 hours

CHRONOMETER-CERTIFIED RESERVE ON THE HAND-WOUND B09 — NEARLY THREE DAYS, WHICH IS THE HONEST ARGUMENT FOR LEAVING THE ROTOR OUT[1]

SOURCES 1 Breitling's own Singapore and United States storefronts, read 27–28 October, where the S$10,450 and the six dollar references appear; European figures from two independent watch titles; the specification figures from one title's own table and a second's hands-on, both read in full. 2 Oracle of Time, 22 October — **the contradiction is within that single page, body against specification box, and is reported rather than resolved.** A Swiss franc figure appeared only in a search summary and is not printed. 3 The comment thread under Fratello's launch piece, 22–23 October, quoted by handle and read at source. **Hodinkee and WatchUSeek were unreachable from this desk — one blocked, one behind a payment wall — so the enthusiast read is narrower than it should be and says so.** 4 Victor777 in the same thread; the structural argument and the falsification test are this desk's.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE SPLIT WEEKEND

Waititi's *Klara and the Sun* opens to $701,059 from 880 theatres

The $20m Ishiguro adaptation took a Sunday per-theatre average of $198 and drew zero positive notices on Metacritic, while Wicker, made for $10m, took $5.75m at 95 per cent on Rotten Tomatoes.

Two semi-wide films opened on 23 October and went opposite ways. Taika Waititi's adaptation of Kazuo Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun*, with Jenna Ortega and Amy Adams, took $701,059 from 880 theatres for fourteenth place. The decay inside the weekend is the story: Friday $282,867, Saturday down 14.0 per cent, Sunday down a further 28.1 to a per-theatre average of $198. The budget was $20m; the opening had been projected at $2m.[1]

The notices explain the Sunday. Metacritic has it at 30 from 26 reviews — zero positive, 12 mixed, 14 negative. Rotten Tomatoes read 24 per cent from 75 critics on Wednesday, against an audience score of 78. Stephanie Bunbury in the Financial Times, two stars: the story "just bounces along, standing uncertainly on one leg and then the other". James Berardinelli: "Waititi wants to adapt rather than create."[2]

Wicker, directed by Alex Huston Fischer and Eleanor Wilson with Olivia Colman — who also produced — opened to $5,745,945 from 1,471 theatres for fifth, a per-theatre average of $3,906 on a $10m budget. Rotten Tomatoes has it at 95 per cent from 131 critics, audience 92; a PostTrak poll gave 72 per cent "definitely recommend".[3]

Its Metacritic 70, though, conceals a wider argument than the aggregate suggests. The New York Times scored it 100 — "funny and freaky and sweetly romantic" — while the Telegraph scored it 20, saying it "loses its nerve" whenever it approaches real emotional drama. One number, two films.[3]

> *"I wanted Klara to burst out of that box coffin and start M3ganing the entire human race."*

THE CHARTS

Britain. The Official Singles Chart dated 23 October has Jamie Miller's "BABYDOLL" at number one, Tate McRae's "HOUSEWIFE" a new entry at two, and Fontaines D.C. taking two new entries in one week at 14 and 18. The chart publishes no sales or streaming figure, so none is printed here.[4]

America, held. Ella Langley's "Choosin' Texas" is reported back at number one on the Hot 100 for a 25th non-consecutive week, described as the longest run at the top in the chart's history. Billboard's own pages redirect to a paywall that returns a payment-required error to this desk, so the figure is held at one outlet and no units are printed.[4]

THE CHATTER · LETTERBOXD WAS KINDER THAN THE CRITICS

Audiences and critics parted company on *Klara* by fifty-four points, and the user reviews show why. Kylo, four stars: "I wanted Klara to burst out of that box coffin and start M3gan-ing the entire human race." jonathan fujii, two: "It actually shows some heart when it's not trying to be a Ryan Reynolds movie." On *Wicker*, which has 124 fans listed against *Klara*'s 73: Gloria, four stars, "I'll have what shes having..!"; mia lee vicino, "best bed-breaking scene since Twilight Breaking Dawn Part 1".

THE SCEPTIC · A PER-THEATRE AVERAGE IS NOT A VERDICT

The temptation is to read $198 as a referendum on the film. It is partly a referendum on the booking: 880 theatres for a prestige literary adaptation with a four-week festival gap after its London premiere on 15 October is a release pattern that produces this number whatever the picture is like. The counter-evidence is that the audience score sits at 78 while the critics sit at 24, which is not the shape of a film nobody can watch.

0 of 26

POSITIVE NOTICES FOR *KLARA AND THE SUN* ON METACRITIC — TWELVE MIXED, FOURTEEN NEGATIVE, AND NOT ONE IN THE GREEN[2]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend table for 2026 weekend 43 and the film's own release page, both read at source on 28 October; budget and projection from the film's production record. 2 Metacritic's own score page, read 28 October, including its positive/mixed/negative split; the Rotten Tomatoes figure is the count as read on the same day and is still moving — the film's own record cites 25 per cent from 68. Review quotations read at Metacritic's excerpt listing. 3 Box Office Mojo and Rotten Tomatoes for *Wicker*; the Times and Telegraph scores and quoted lines from Metacritic's own page. 4 The Official Charts Company's chart dated 23 October, read at source.

THE FAMILY DESK · A SINGAPORE REANALYSIS

Bavelier's team re-reads 3,434 Singapore pupils: hours did not predict harm

In PLoS One on 21 October, a reanalysis of a 2007–09 schools cohort finds that among the heaviest gamers — averaging 57 hours a week — change in impulse control explained the symptoms, not change in playing time.

A team led by Benoit Bediou and Daphne Bavelier, with Douglas Gentile — who co-authored the original Singapore work — published a reanalysis in PLoS One on 21 October 2026. The cohort is 3,434 pupils in six primary and six secondary schools in Singapore, Primary 3 and 4 and Secondary 1 and 2, which the paper gives as roughly 11 to 13 years old: the band that actually contains a Secondary 1 child.[1]

They split the children four ways by how much they played. The heaviest group — 785 children playing more than 28 hours a week — averaged about 57 hours a week. Then they followed each child across three waves a year apart and asked what predicted a change in problematic-gaming symptoms.[1]

The answer depends on who you ask about. Among occasional players, change in hours explained about 12 per cent of the variance in symptom change. Among heavy players, change in impulsiveness explained about 11 per cent while hours explained about 7. And in the cross-lagged models there was no significant within-person link between gaming hours and problematic gaming at all; problematic gaming predicted later impulsiveness, not the reverse. The authors' own summary: "changes in gaming time dominate in occasional use gamers, whereas changes in impulse control dominate in heavy use gamers".[1]

> *"The disease model of gaming disorder can stigmatize healthy game users."*

THE CHATTER · THE PARENT FORUMS COULD NOT BE READ

This box would normally carry what parents are saying. It cannot. Reddit is blocked to this desk, Mumsnet served navigation with no thread list, one British parenting site is blocked outright and a Singapore parenting forum returned 403. Rather than substitute a quote from somewhere else and imply it came from a parent, the desk reports the gap. What can be said is that the finding cuts against the standard household rule: a screen-time cap is a policy about hours, and this paper says that for the children already past the cap, hours were not the variable that moved.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · A NAMED RESEARCHER ON MORAL PANIC

Christopher Ferguson, with Sung Je Lee, So Young Kim and Eui Jun Jeong, published the don't-be-alarmist case in Frontiers in Psychology on 2 January 2026: a survey of 2,000 South Koreans aged 15 to 60. Feeling responsible for media threats predicted negative attitudes to games at β = 0.711, and those attitudes predicted agreement with pathologising gaming disorder at β = 0.467, an indirect effect of 0.332 with a confidence interval of 0.277 to 0.394. Their own line: moral panic "could act as a stumbling block to the correct understanding of the object".

57 hours

A WEEK, AVERAGED, IN THE HEAVIEST-GAMING QUARTER OF A SINGAPORE SCHOOLS COHORT AGED ROUGHLY ELEVEN TO THIRTEEN[1]

General guidance, not medical advice. The practical reading is narrow and worth stating narrowly: for a child whose play is occasional, time limits are doing real work. For a child already deep in it, this paper says the thing to watch is whether they can stop when they mean to — and it says so on 2009 data, without confidence intervals, in a sample that was three-quarters boys.[1]

SOURCES 1 Bediou, Cekic, Gentile and Bavelier, "Problematic gaming in occasional, low, intermediate or heavy use gamers — not all screen time is created equal — A reanalysis", PLoS One 21(10): e0356080, published 21 October 2026, read in full at the journal. Every figure, caveat and internal inconsistency above is stated in or derived from that paper.

THE TWEEN YEARS · TURKEY'S AGE RULE

From 1 November, Turkey bars under-15s from social media entirely

The regulation Ankara gazetted on 10 October orders providers to reject applications from children under 15, and forbids infinite scroll, autoplay and live streaming for 15- to 17-year-olds.

Turkey's Cyber Security Presidency gazetted a regulation on 10 October 2026 that takes effect on 1 November, and it is the most absolute age rule any country has written. The wording is flat: "social network providers are prohibited from providing services to children under the age of 15". Applications from under-15s must be rejected, existing accounts closed after notice, and every unverified legacy account checked by 31 March 2027.[1]

What happens at fifteen is the part worth a parent's attention, because it legislates the mechanics rather than the access. For 15- to 17-year-olds, accounts are private by default with no option to go public, follower lists hidden, messages only from accounts the child follows, no read receipts, no contact-list access, no recommendation of the account to others, no live streaming, no endless scroll or autoplay feeds, technical measures against screenshots, and no behavioural profiling or personalised advertising.[1]

Verification runs through the state's e-government gateway, and the credential is deliberately thin: it "will indicate only whether the user has reached the ages of 15 and 18" — not identity, not an exact age. Parental tools must be in Turkish, must cover settings, purchase approval, time limits and location sharing, and must be hard for a child to switch off. Penalties exist under the governing law; providers get notice and a remedy period first, and no fine amounts are published.[1]

Florida is pulling the same way with far less force. Attorney-General James Uthmeier unveiled a "Safe Screens Act" on 22 October that would age-verify every app-store user, cap teen screen time at two hours a day and sixty a month, and impose a quiet mode from 11pm to 7am and 8am to 3pm on school days — with the proposal stating that "muting notifications is not enough". It has no legislative sponsor, the attorney-general cannot introduce it, and the earliest session that could hear it opens on 2 March 2027.[2]

> *"Age-signal systems expand the collection of sensitive demographic data on a mass scale."*

THE CHATTER · WHAT A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD WOULD NOTICE

Strip the law to what changes on a phone. Under the Turkish rule a child of this reader's daughter's age simply has no account — and when she turns fifteen, the platform is forbidden from giving her the feed she would otherwise get. That is a different intervention from a time limit: it removes the two mechanisms, infinite scroll and autoplay, that make the time pass without a decision.

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR HUNDRED COMPUTER SCIENTISTS SIGNED AGAINST IT

The objection to age verification is not that children are safe online. It is that the machinery costs everyone something.

31 Mar 2027

THE DATE BY WHICH EVERY UNVERIFIED LEGACY ACCOUNT IN TURKEY MUST HAVE BEEN CHECKED AGAINST THE STATE GATEWAY[1]

General guidance, not legal advice. Neither rule touches a Singapore household directly. What they offer is a vocabulary: the Turkish regulation separates *access* from *design*, and a parent can borrow the second half without waiting for a statute — most platforms already allow a teen account to be set private, recommendations off and autoplay off, which is three of Ankara's clauses, available tonight, for free.[3]

SOURCES 1 The "Regulation on the Provision of Differentiated Services for Children and Age Verification by Social Network Providers", Official Gazette of 10 October 2026, number 33396, made under Law No. 5651, as summarised in a practitioner analysis read in full; the quoted clauses are the regulation's own wording as that analysis renders them.

THE MACRO DESK · THE REAL YIELD

The US ten-year closed at 4.99, the real yield at 2.64

Treasury's own curves put the ten-year breakeven at 2.35 on 27 October with Brent at $114.22 — the market is pricing the oil shock as temporary and charging the whole cost to the real rate.

The US ten-year par yield closed at 4.99 per cent on 27 October, down a basis point. The ten-year real yield closed at 2.64. Subtract one from the other and the breakeven is 2.35 — this magazine's own arithmetic of two curves the Treasury publishes separately, and which the Federal Reserve's own series prints as 2.35 the same day.[1]

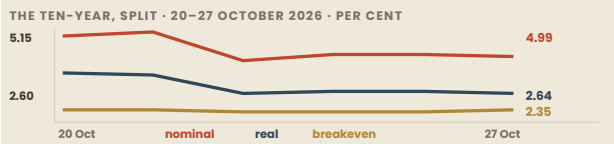
That subtraction is the whole page. Brent settled at $114.22, down 1.37 per cent, after a month in which US crude touched a six-month high. Oil at that level is an inflation shock; a breakeven of 2.35 says the bond market does not expect it to embed. So the cost is charged to the real rate and to the dollar — and 2.64 per cent real is punishing by any standard since 2010.[1]

The Federal Open Market Committee's statement lands at 02:00 Singapore time on Thursday — about twenty-six hours after this page is set. It is priced, not decided. Futures imply roughly a 10 per cent chance of a rise this week; a Reuters poll of 100 economists found 94 expecting a hold and all 100 expecting one in December. Policy stands at 3.75 to 4 per cent.[2]

THE STRIP · AT TUESDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[1]	4.99%	▼ 1bp
10-yr real (TIPS)[1]	2.64%	▼ 2bp
10-yr breakeven[1]	2.35%	▲ 1bp
VWRA	$191.30	▲ 0.63%
Brent	$114.22	▼ 1.37%
Gold	$4,060.08	▲ 1.08%
Bitcoin	$80,655	▲ 0.81%

Each level read at its own source on 27 October. Not advice.[1]



A *Meridian* figure, plotted from the Treasury's own par and real yield curves for 20–27 October. The gold line barely moves: the oil shock is being charged to the real rate, not to expected inflation.

THE CHATTER · DIVERSIFICATION WORKED ONCE THIS MONTH

Take the verified series rather than the theory. On 22 October the S&P fell 1.21 per cent and the ten-year yield fell 17 basis points in the same session: bonds hedged equities, properly, on the day it mattered. But on 20 to 21 October and again on 26 to 27, equities rose and yields fell or held — positive price correlation, both legs riding one impulse.

THE SCEPTIC · MCGEEVER'S STAGFLATIONARY BIND

Jamie McGeever of Reuters wrote the best version of the bear case on 26 October: doubts about artificial-intelligence spending are pushing money into Treasuries at the same moment as energy keeps inflation alive, which leaves the Fed cutting into a price shock or tightening into a growth scare.

What it means for global equities, bonds, gold and bitcoin. One force: the price of duration while a central bank is still tightening into an energy shock. Global equities rose 0.63 per cent but stay 5.4 below their 52-week high, and the bid is narrow — the Nasdaq up 1.18 against a Dow up 0.03. Global bonds went nowhere: a front end pricing December fights a long end pricing the growth cost. Gold rose 1.08 on a day the dollar rose 0.41 — the real-yield channel, not haven demand. Bitcoin at $80,655 is the one line that did not join the rally. Singapore's index fell 0.35. Explanation, not advice, and forecasts are flagged as forecasts.[3]

SOURCES 1 Yields read at the Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves for October 2026; the breakeven is the subtraction, corroborated independently against the Federal Reserve's published series. Equity, bond, commodity and currency levels each read at their own source on 27 October. One provider shows the ten-year at 5.003 per cent against Treasury's official 4.99 — a futures print against the three o'clock curve; the official figure is used. 2 The Federal Reserve's own calendar and its 16 September statement; the pricing and the poll from a pre-meeting preview, with a second source putting the hold probability at 88 per cent rather than 90. The futures exchange's own tool returned a server error for a fourth issue running. 3 Jamie McGeever, Reuters, 26 October, read at a licensed republisher — reuters.com itself refused this desk. The two reconciliations are ours. No ECB policy rate is printed because none could be verified at source.

THE RABBIT HOLE · DARKROOM PRINTING

A survey of 5,439 printers by Ilford blames cost and space

The answers Ilford got were cost and space, not mystique — and 86 per cent of non-printers said they would try it if that one obstacle were removed.

Here is the whole craft in a sentence. You shine light from an enlarger through a developed negative onto silver-gelatin paper, under a safelight, for a measured number of seconds; then the paper goes through developer, stop, fixer and a wash. Nothing is automatic. Contrast is a separate dial from brightness. The negative is fixed, and every print off it is a different performance.[1]

That last point is what hooks people, and it is why the enthusiasts talk about printing the way musicians talk about playing. Tom Warland, who teaches photography in Buckinghamshire and runs a monthly live printing stream, calls the darkroom "an emotional refuge" with "a genuinely calming effect", and started with "an enlarger balanced on a washing basket" and trays in the bathtub. His own observation is the one that frames this desk: a great many film photographers "have never experienced printing first-hand".[1]

The scale of the world is smaller than the enthusiasm suggests, and it is measured. Ilford ran a global darkroom-printing survey in late 2019 that drew 5,439 responses from 87 countries, split 69 per cent printers to 31 per cent non-printers. Of the non-printers, 86 per cent said they would try printing if their single main obstacle were addressed, and a further 9 per cent if two or three were. The two obstacles named most often were cost and lack of space. Its biennial film survey drew over 8,500 replies in 2022.[2]

The industry behind it is smaller still. Harman — which owns Ilford Photo and Kentmere, was formed in 2005 by former managers of Ilford Imaging UK, and is named for Alfred Harman, who founded the original firm in 1879 — describes itself as "one of the world's last remaining companies capable of the full end-to-end process". That is the honest market figure, because the published market-size estimates are not usable: every one this desk found came from an aggregator whose own numbers contradicted each other.[3]

> *"Then finally there they were… image after image of my oldest mate, his wife and their newborn daughter."*

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

The community map — where printers actually gather, and the argument that has run since 2014. **The gear** — what is still manufactured, what the used market really costs, and the German retrofit business that is the only modern change to the craft. **The culture** — split grade, the test strip, and what a print costs per sheet. **The first ninety days** — including the one public darkroom in Singapore, its price, and its catch. **And the sceptic**, who is the craft's own trade.

THE CHATTER · WHY PEOPLE SAY THEY CAME BACK

The accounts are consistent and they are not about image quality. Michael Jardine returned to printing during lockdown while caring alone for a young child, and credits it "with keeping hold of any kind of sanity". David Pauley calls his home darkroom "a playground and a refuge".

THE SCEPTIC · THE SURVEY NUMBER CUTS BOTH WAYS

Warland ran an Instagram poll in which 92 per cent of respondents said they preferred a print to a scanned negative. It is his poll, of his audience, and it measures the enthusiasm of people already following a darkroom printer — which is exactly the selection Ilford's survey avoided and exactly the one this desk should not launder into a general fact. The defensible version is Ilford's: a hobby whose own manufacturer found that the barrier is a room and a budget, not a secret. Everything on the next two pages is an answer to cost or to space, and the ones that answer neither are the ones to be careful of.[2]

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THE SPLIT BETWEEN PRINTERS AND NON-PRINTERS AMONG 5,439 RESPONDENTS TO ILFORD'S GLOBAL DARKROOM SURVEY[2]

SOURCES 1 Tom Warland, "Printing Live", 35mmc, 30 October 2025, read in full, together with its signed comment thread, from which the Jardine and Pauley lines are taken; the first-timer's account from the same site, 16 February 2024; Olivier Desmet, same site, 15 November 2025.

The used market is where this craft actually lives, and it is extraordinary. On the German classifieds on 27 October a Durst M605 was €149; an M601 with a colour mixing head *and* a Schneider Componon-S lens was €150; an M600 was free. A Durst Laborator 1200 with a CLS 450 colour head — the serious four-by-five chassis — was €850 in Munich. A Leitz Focomat IIc, fully working, was €475 in Stuttgart. A defective Focomat V35 was €55.[1]

New machines still exist, and the list is short: Kaiser in Germany, LPL in Japan, Beseler in America, Paterson, and Intrepid in Britain. The one worth knowing is the LPL 7700 VCCE at £1,440, whose two-channel head carries a neutral-density filter that inserts and removes itself automatically so the exposure stays constant as you change contrast grade — the single most useful feature on any variable-contrast head. Intrepid's Compact Enlarger is £300 and in stock, shipping in one to two days; it began as a Kickstarter in March 2021 at £220 that funded in a little over five minutes.[2]

Then there is the retrofit, and it is the only genuine modern change to the craft. Heiland Electronic of Wetzlar builds LED cold-light heads for about thirty named enlargers, from €589 for a Leitz V35 to €6,949 for a DeVere 12×16. Its largest European dealer lists 93 Heiland items, 88 of them special order, and on 27 October exactly one of the thirty heads was in stock. The Splitgrade controller was sold out. For the motorised systems the dealer states the process plainly: you buy the system for your head type, then the head "must be sent to Fotoimpex in Bad Saarow after purchase for customization". No lead time and no deposit terms are published anywhere, which is itself the description of this tier.[3]

What the controller buys is the guessing. You meter the lightest highlight and the darkest shadow on the easel, and it proposes an exposure to one-tenth of a stop and one-tenth of a grade from more than 30 built-in paper calibrations, then runs the print as a two-phase soft-then-hard exposure so you can dodge in either phase. It costs €889.[3]

€2,666 of electronics, bolted to a €149 casting.

THE INVERSION, IN ONE LINE OF ARITHMETIC

A Durst M605 costs €149 used. The Heiland LED head for it is €1,189, the Splitgrade controller €889, the LED adapter €229 and the Comfort add-on €359. That is **€2,666 of electronics on a €149 lump of iron** — and it is the most revealing fact in this desk's research. The alternative, the LPL 7700 at £1,440, gets you automatic contrast out of the box and no soldering.[3]

Lenses and the rest. A Schneider Componon-S 50mm f/2.8 is €49 to €60 used; a Rodagon 80mm f/4 about €120; the grail **Apo-Rodagon N 105mm f/4** is €1,250. Timers: RH Designs' **StopClock Pro** £399 and **Analyser B&W Pro** £469. **Beseler, Omega and LPL used prices are deliberately absent from this page: they live on two American marketplaces that both refused this desk, and nothing was invented to fill the gap.**[1]

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENT THAT HAS RUN SINCE 2014

Eleven minutes apart in one thread on a British forum, two printers set out the whole dispute. steveo_mcg: "Film and darkroom prints have been replaced by digital, in almost every measurable way digital is better." Steve Smith: "you cannot equal a black and white print produced on film and printed on proper photographic paper by digital methods." Kevin Allan adds the practical warning everybody forgets: an enlarger "is however extremely heavy so you wouldn't want to be moving it in and out of a temporary darkroom".

THE SCEPTIC · THE PARTS CLIFF IS REAL

Durst's commercial enlarger division is closed. The two parts specialists the forums name could not be verified to exist at all from here — both domains failed to resolve, and a post from around 2023 reports that one of them lost its owner. So the community's standing advice is to buy a second machine as a donor. On a market where an M605 is €149 that is sensible and cheap. On a Laborator 1200 at €850 or a Focomat IIc at €475 it is an argument for buying the common machine rather than the beautiful one — which is the opposite of what buy-once usually means.[4]

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HEILAND ITEMS LISTED AS SPECIAL ORDER AT ITS LARGEST EUROPEAN DEALER — A BUILD-TO-ORDER BUSINESS, NOT A SHELF BUSINESS[3]

€6,949

THE LED HEAD FOR A DEVERE 12×16 — MORE THAN A JOBO PROCESSOR AND A NEW LPL ENLARGER TOGETHER[3]

SOURCES 1 Live asking prices read on the German classifieds on 2 Firstcall Photographic's own catalogue, read 3 Heiland pricing, stock and the customisation process read at Fotoimpex, Heiland's largest European dealer, on 4 Forum discussion visible only as search listings, and reported as unverified for that reason; the conclusion is this desk's.

The craft's signature technique is split-grade printing: two exposures through two filters, soft then hard, instead of one through a middle grade. Its best teacher is also its best sceptic. Sroyon Mukherjee, whose five-part series is where most printers learn it, writes that "any straight split grade print can be replicated with a single exposure using the right combination of colour filters", rejects the claim that it unlocks tones nothing else can reach, and finishes: "I can't even say for sure if split grade works for me, let alone if it will work for you." His actual reason for doing it is the honest one: "split grade printing just feels cool."[1]

What no amount of equipment removes is the test strip. Ken Rowin: even reprinting "the same negative at the same size on the same paper" gives a slightly different result, so he still makes one. Joe Van Cleave finds plain fixed-interval strips faster than the clever methods. And Fidel, who bought this year's new timer, uses "only the fstop portion for my test strips" and switches back to an ordinary timer once the times are set.[1]

The paper is the consumable and it is where the money actually goes. Ilford Multigrade FB Classic glossy at eight by ten is £1.50 a sheet in hundreds; resin-coated is £0.94; sixteen by twenty is £5.99 and twenty by twenty-four is £8.53. But nobody gets it on the first sheet. Reckon on two to four sheets for a print you keep, which puts a finished eight-by-ten fibre print at £4.50 to £7.50 in materials and a finished sixteen-by-twenty at £18 to £30. That multiplier is this desk's estimate; the sheet prices are not.[2]

> *"Ilford/Harman use a special printer. It does do silver gelatin prints but they're from scans."*

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, AND THE SINGAPORE CATCH

Rent before you buy. **Objectifs**, 155 Middle Road, reopened its darkroom after a nine-year gap and rents it at **S$40 for the first two hours and S$15 an hour after**, Thursday and Friday afternoons and Saturday late. Chemicals for developing *and* printing are included; you bring paper. **The catch is in their own rule: you must already know how to use an enlarger.** The introductory class that teaches you — four Saturdays, **S$320 plus S$70 of materials — is full for 2026, waitlist only.**[3]

The buy-once list, about £500. Intrepid Compact Enlarger £300 (LED, built-in timer and filters, small enough for a cupboard); a used Componon-S 50mm at €49–60; a Beseler masking frame £80.48; a Heiland LED safelight €42; Ilford RC Deluxe pearl, 100 sheets, £96.18; developer, stop and fixer about £52. Learn on resin-coated paper — it dries in an hour in a flat. **Do not buy on day one:** an analyser, a Heiland head, a Splitgrade, a Jobo or a fibre washer. Each solves a problem you have not had yet.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TROPICS ACTUALLY CHANGE

This is the part the literature does not cover, and the desk will not pretend otherwise. No Singapore-specific source on darkroom water temperature or humidity could be found. What the catalogue shows is suggestive in one direction: the entire accessory market exists to *heat* water — tempering baths, immersion heaters, processors costing thousands.

THE SCEPTIC · THE TRADE SAYS DIGITAL IS CHEAPER, AND HARMAN AGREES

The sharpest dissent comes from inside the business. A British trade printer, posting as AgPhotographic: "There is, bluntly, a massive cost advantage with digital exposure / wet process as opposed to hand enlarging," with the Ilford silver-gelatin paper costing several times what their usual stock does.

NEXT DESCENTS

Marquetry & wood veneer inlay — the knife, the donkey, and pictures made of shaved trees.

Orienteering — map, compass, forest and a clock; a thinking endurance sport with a cheap entry.

Home cheesemaking — cultures, rennet and a cave in a wine fridge; patience measured in months.

The year's honest scoreboard. One genuinely new thing shipped: an open-source f-stop timer, announced in May and selling at $300 assembled or $200 as a bare board, undercutting a £399 incumbent whose own website still carries a 2020 copyright line and an unedited placeholder heading. One thing died: a daylight enlarger whose maker wrote plainly, "I was unable to secure the funding needed to turn the idea into a full product." And from the industry's largest manufacturer, in twelve months, four film accessories and a collector's-edition film box — and no darkroom product at all.[5]

SOURCES 1 Sroyon Mukherjee, "Split Grade Printing", 35mmc, 27 April 2020, read in full; the Rowin, Van Cleave and Fidel lines from signed comment threads on the same site. 2 Paper and chemistry prices read at a British specialist and a German maker on 27 October; **the per-sheet costs are published prices divided by sheet count, and the two-to-four-sheet multiplier is this desk's own estimate.** 3 Objectifs' own rental and workshop pages. **No other public darkroom in Singapore could be verified.** 4 Makers' and retailers' own pages. 5 Talk Photography, 2014 and 2018, by handle — **Photrio, the large-format forum and Reddit all refused this desk.**

FITNESS · COMMITMENT DEVICES

A Singapore meta-analysis finds staking money adds 665 steps a day

Published in the European Journal of Preventive Cardiology on 26 October, the pooled estimate across 29 randomised trials has a confidence interval of 463 to 867 steps and heterogeneity of zero.

A team led by Chew Han Shi Jocelyn at the National University of Singapore published a systematic review and meta-analysis in the European Journal of Preventive Cardiology on 26 October 2026, pooling 29 randomised trials and 7,534 adults with raised cardiometabolic risk. The question was narrow: does a digital commitment device — an app that makes you stake money or social standing on a behaviour — actually change it?[1]

On steps, yes, and unusually cleanly. The pooled difference is 664.87 steps a day, confidence interval 463.22 to 866.51, $p < 0.00001$, and — the figure that matters — $I^2 = 0$ per cent. Twenty-nine trials, run by different teams in different countries, and they agree almost perfectly.[1]

> *"The finding for VO2max should be interpreted with caution."*

THE SAME LITERATURE, TWO ANSWERS

Two 2026 meta-analyses of roughly the same twenty-odd "exercise snacks" trials reached opposite verdicts on the same outcome. One, published **10 August**, pooled **21 trials and 921 participants** and rated the VO2max gain at **$g = 1.04$** with **moderate** certainty — despite its own publication-bias tests coming back at Egger's **$p < 0.001$** and Begg's **$p = 0.006$**. The other, published **28 September**, pooled **22 studies and 994 participants**, found **$g = 1.24$** — and then corrected for publication bias with trim-and-fill, at which point the effect fell to **$g = 0.62$** with an interval of **−0.59 to 1.83** and **$p = 0.32$**. **Null.** Its own authors write that the VO2max finding "should be interpreted with caution", and its registration was filed after its search closed.[2]

THE CHATTER · THE ATHLETE'S HEART, READ CAREFULLY

Brady Holmer, an exercise physiologist, spent his 23 October newsletter on the finding that worries endurance athletes most: that the heavily trained show *more* coronary calcium, not less. His summary of the literature he cites: in one Dutch cohort of 284 men averaging 55, the most-trained more often had calcium above zero than the least active, with more calcified and fewer mixed plaques; in a 2025 follow-up of 289 men, family history was the strongest predictor of severe calcium, each decade of age meant 92 per cent higher risk of a score above 100, while each ten MET-hours a week of training meant 11 per cent.

THE SCEPTIC · A ZERO THAT SHOULD MAKE YOU SUSPICIOUS

$I^2 = 0$ per cent across twenty-nine independent trials is a remarkable claim, and remarkable claims in this literature usually mean something about the measurement rather than the world. A step count is machine-recorded, which removes the reporting noise that makes weight trials disagree — so the clean figure and the messy one may simply be the same effect measured well and measured badly. There is also a nine-month gap between the two meta-analyses on the facing argument and no replication between them.

General guidance, not medical advice. The usable reading for a mid-forties reader is modest and worth keeping modest: a stake makes a small, real, machine-measured difference to how much you walk, and the evidence that it changes your body is much weaker than the evidence that it changes your step count. Everything beyond that — the snacks, the VO2max gain, the calcium score — is a literature still arguing with itself in public, which is the healthiest state a literature can be in.[3]

SOURCES 1 Chen, Goh, Chew and Chew, "Effectiveness of Digital Commitment Devices in Improving Lifestyle and Cardiometabolic Outcomes in Adults with Cardiometabolic Risk Factors", European Journal of Preventive Cardiology, published online 26 October 2026; abstract and competing-interests statement read at source. **The funding statement could not be read and is not characterised here.** 2 Two 2026 meta-analyses of the exercise-snacks literature, published 10 August and 28 September, both read at source including their own bias tests and registration dates — **both sit outside a strict two-week window and are carried as the sceptical frame, not the news peg.** 3 Brady Holmer, 23 October 2026, read in full; **the cohort figures are his citations as he reports them. Reddit refused this desk.** Not medical advice.

THE DIARY · ONE DATE THAT MATTERS

Advance sales for Tokyo's January sumo tournament open on 5 December

The November tournament in Fukuoka is already sold out on all fifteen days, which is the evidence that the 5 December window is the one to diary — and Wild Rice opens Monkey Goes West on 12 November.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

12 Nov–27 Dec ★ *Monkey Goes West* · Wild Rice
NGEE ANN KONGSI THEATRE, FUNAN · ON SALE · PREVIEWS S$50–95; FRI–SUN S$60–120 · AGES 5 UP; RELAXED PERFORMANCE 20 DEC

27–29 Nov ★ Anime Festival Asia 2026
SUNTEC, HALLS 401–406, 10AM–8PM · NO PRICES PUBLISHED ON THE OFFICIAL SITE · KYARY PAMYU PAMYU, A HATSUNE MIKU NIGHT, FRIEREN ON THE DAY STAGE

13–22 Nov Singapore Writers Festival · "Hidden in Plain Sight"
VICTORIA THEATRE AND THE ARTS HOUSE · PASS S$30, YOUTH S$15 · 100+ PROGRAMMES

20–29 Nov Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts
ESPLANADE · NO PRICES PUBLISHED

27 Feb–14 Mar *Goldilocks and the Three Wild Boars*
WILD RICE @ FUNAN · AGES 5 UP · NOT YET ON SALE — THE VENUE SAYS TICKETS OPEN IN 2027. DIARY IT, DO NOT CLICK

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

10–24 Jan ★ Grand Sumo · Hatsu Basho
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · ADVANCE SALE OPENS SAT 5 DEC · PRICES ON A SEPARATE PAGE THIS DESK COULD NOT REACH

8–22 Nov Grand Sumo · Kyushu Basho
FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · SOLD OUT ON ALL FIFTEEN DAYS, CONFIRMED ON BOTH THE ASSOCIATION'S SITE AND THE OFFICIAL TICKET SERVICE — THE COUNTERPOINT TO THE DATE ABOVE

4–11 Feb ★ 77th Sapporo Snow Festival
ODORI, TSUDOME AND SUSUKINO, HOKKAIDO · TSUDOME IS THE SITE FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD · THE OFFICIAL SITE CARRIES NO ADMISSION STATEMENT; 2027 VENUE DETAIL DUE MID-DECEMBER

2–3 Dec Chichibu Yomatsuri · night float festival
CHICHIBU, SAITAMA — 80 MINUTES FROM IKEBUKURO · UNESCO-LISTED · NO GRANDSTAND PRICES PUBLISHED

7 MAR Tokyo Marathon 2027
GENERAL LOTTERY ALREADY CLOSED, RESULTS ISSUED 11 SEP; CHARITY CLOSED 9 JUL · VOLUNTEER ENTRY IS OPEN, GLOBAL WINDOW 4–23 NOV · A PLANNING FIXTURE, NOT BOOKABLE

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS PAGE WILL NOT LIST

The entire arena slate is missing from the left column and the reason is sourcing, not scarcity. Singapore's two main ticketing sites returned 403 and a client-side render with zero results to every attempt, so a dozen stadium and indoor dates that circulate freely on listings sites — including four December nights widely reported sold out — are unconfirmed at any primary source and are therefore absent. Also absent, and for better reasons: Christmas Wonderland has published no 2026 dates and its own site still serves last year's page; the Standard Chartered marathon site still carries 2025; Chingay 2027 has no dates.

SOURCES 1 Named refusals, each attempted repeatedly: one national ticketing site returned 403 on every path and the other renders client-side and served zero results; the sports-hub, Burpple and two listings titles also refused. **Two dead events stand in this magazine's ledger and appear nowhere above.** The Fukuoka tournament is listed as unbookable rather than omitted, because the sell-out is the fact.

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW ROOMS

Matsuya opens at Suntec, last of Japan's big three gyudon chains

Gyumeshi runs from S$5.50 to S$10.90 with no service charge and no tax on top; the grand opening is 31 October, and two outlets disagree about which unit number it occupies.

Matsuya has soft-opened at Suntec City, making it the last of Japan's three big gyudon chains to reach Singapore after Sukiya, here since 2021, and Yoshinoya, here two decades. The brand runs more than 1,500 outlets; ordering is by self-service kiosk and there is no chef attached, because this is a chain debut rather than a chef story. Prices are net — no service charge, no tax added — from S$5.50 for a small beef bowl to S$10.90 for the largest, with curry rice from S$6.90, a hamburg-and-cheese curry at S$14.40 and unagi from S$12.50. Not halal-certified. The grand opening is 31 October; until then it trades 11am–3pm and 5pm–9pm, and after it, 9am–10pm.[1]

It has been eaten, once, on a hosted tasting, and the reviewer was careful. The verdict: "we can say Matsuya Singapore is definitely a great option to have", against the "average-but-overpriced" Japanese chains in local malls; the hamburg "tender and paired well with Matsuya's curry"; the unagi "soft and well-glazed, without being cloying". And the dissent is in the same piece: the smallest bowl "just won't leave you overly full" and its flavour is "on the lighter side"; the grilled pork "nowhere near mind-blowing"; the unagi not up to a specialist's. He declines to predict whether it will match its two rivals here.[1]

Xiao Jiao Tian has opened its second Singapore outlet at Wisma Atria, on the third floor, daily 10am to 10pm. Founded in Fujian in 2013 and now running more than 80 kitchens across China and Singapore, it cooks Sichuan-leaning food deliberately milder than the mainland original, every dish to order, and offers a dish free if it falls short of the house standard. Bullfrog with pickled chilli is the signature at S$39.90++, crispy roast chicken S$45.90++, sauerkraut fish S$29.90++ with adjustable heat. The opening deal is the reason to go early: free-flow tea, ice cream, snacks and rice at S$1.50++ a head instead of S$3.[2]

Two smaller rooms complete the page. Foca Kumpir at Siglap Centre is billed as Singapore's first kumpir restaurant — the Turkish baked potato, split and mashed in its skin with butter and cheese, then loaded. Plain S$6, three toppings S$9, the upper tier S$12; no founders are named anywhere, so none are invented here. And Ng Kuan Chilli Pan Mee is at hoarding stage at Century Square, opening mid-November as the brand's fifth outlet: signature ban mian S$6.50 in soup, S$6.80 dry, with minced pork, ikan bilis, a runny egg and chilli infused with dried shrimp.[3]

THE BUZZ · ONE VERDICT, ONE PREVIEW, TWO BLANKS

The honest state of the page: of four rooms, one has been eaten and written up, one has a news write-up with no verdict at all, one has a single first-hand review, and one has not opened. On the Siglap potato shop the reviewer was "actually surprised" and called it "a gem that's worth revisiting more often" — the potatoes "nicely seasoned, fluffy, and slightly creamy", the Turkish pepper relish "a very tangy and fragrant base" — while saying of the bolognese, "it's not incredible". On the Orchard room the only evidence of traction is that three named local food accounts were photographing it within days, which is activity, not consensus. Too new to call, said four times rather than papered over.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · A CHAIN DEBUT IS NOT A RESTAURANT OPENING

The anticipation around the beef-bowl arrival is brand-driven, not queue-driven: nobody has reported a line, and the two pieces in existence are a hosted tasting and a pre-opening preview. Worth noting what else is unresolved — the two outlets covering it give different unit numbers, B1-149/149A against #B1-125, and different Japan outlet counts, about 1,200 against more than 1,500. The practical trick is the soft-launch split hours: the 3pm–5pm gap closes on 31 October, after which it runs straight through and the dead zone disappears. Reddit and one review platform were unreachable from this desk, so where this page says no chatter was found, it means not found, not absent.[4]

SUNTEC · NET PRICING · TOO NEW TO CALL · OPENS MID-NOVEMBER · KIOSK, NO BOOKINGS

SOURCES 1 A Singapore food title's first-hand account of 26 October, which declares its tasting was hosted, read in full with its eight original photographs; a second title's pre-opening preview of 19 October for the chain's background and its Japan menu benchmarks.

THE UNDERCURRENT · AUSTRALIA'S PAYMENT RAILS

Australia banned card surcharges; Macquarie's DEFT stopped taking cards

From 1 October the fee had to vanish from every Australian receipt. Where a price could be raised it rose about eight times the fee; where it could not — rent, strata levies, the tax bill — the card was withdrawn instead.

On 1 October 2026 Australia abolished card surcharges. The Reserve Bank, which had legalised them in the first place, lifted its prohibition on the networks' no-surcharge rules, cut the domestic consumer-credit interchange cap from 0.8 to 0.3 per cent, and put a 1.0 per cent cap on foreign-issued cards. Its own numbers: 16 per cent of Australian merchants surcharged in 2024/25, charging about $1.8bn, of which consumers paid about $1.6bn. Merchants were expected to save about $910m a year in wholesale costs.[1]

Six weeks on, the story everyone is reporting is the one you can see: cafés adding fifty cents to a flat white. The story nobody has reported is the one you can no longer do.

On 6 July, Macquarie Bank issued a variation notice to the billers who use DEFT, the rail through which a large share of Australian rent and strata levies are paid. The wording is not ambiguous: "Card payments (including credit and debit cards) will no longer be available as a payment method through deft.com.au for your payers, effective 1 October 2026. This change applies to both one-off payments and recurring direct debit arrangements set up with a card." Scheduled card payments falling after that date were cancelled automatically. Payers were pushed to bank transfer, direct debit, or the counter at Australia Post — by eftpos, or by cheque.[2]

It was not alone. Stratapay made card acceptance opt-in, scheme by scheme, with the owners' corporation carrying the cost. RentMate ended cards on the same day. And the Australian Taxation Office announced it would stop accepting credit cards rather than absorb the fees — Commissioner Rob Heferen: "It is not tenable for the ATO to absorb the costs associated with accepting credit cards on an ongoing basis," a bill he put at almost $200m annually. After a political row the deadline moved from 30 November 2026 to 30 June 2027, with extra funding from the Treasurer to pay for the delay.[3]

> *"Consumers are already paying these costs via payment surcharges — which are not included in the Consumer Price Index."*

Now put the two halves side by side, because the arithmetic is the argument.

A café owner interviewed on the day the ban began said her customers had been paying a 1.3 per cent surcharge and that 98 per cent of them paid by card. On a flat white averaging $5.09 in September, 1.3 per cent is 6.6 cents. A one-man price index that has telephoned its way to live prices in 13,386 cafés compared 3,309 of them against their own September price: 20 per cent raised, 72 per cent held, 8 per cent read lower. Of the 656 that raised, the average rise was 55 cents, or 11.9 per cent — roughly eight times the fee they had lost. Across every café including those that held, the average rose 6 cents, which is almost exactly the fee removed.[4]

SOURCES 1 Reserve Bank of Australia, *Review of Merchant Card Payment Costs and Surcharging — Conclusions Paper*, March 2026; the document was downloaded and its text read here. All figures in the opening paragraph are its own. 2 Macquarie Bank's own variation notice to DEFT billers, dated 6 July 2026, read at source as published, together with the customer-facing change page and the bank's own template letter to tenants. 3 The Stratapay, RentMate and tax-office changes as a consumer-finance title reported them on 5 and 9 October; the commissioner's quotation and the $200m figure as a news agency carried them on 9 October. **The tax office's own site returns 403 to this desk on every page, so its statements are read in Australian press rather than at the agency.** 4 The café price tracker, read at source on 27 October, together with a business title's earlier snapshot of 7 October; the 1.3 per cent and 98 per cent are one proprietor's, quoted in a national daily on 2 October. **The eight-times comparison is this desk's own arithmetic of those published figures.**

So two groups faced the same rule and did opposite things, and the variable that sorted them was not goodwill. It was whether they were allowed to change their price.

A café can. A menu is a price list its owner writes, and a nationally announced rule change is the cheapest cover a small business will ever get for a reprice it has been postponing. Menu prices move rarely, because each move costs goodwill; when a legitimising public event arrives, the postponed increases arrive with it. Hence fifty-five cents against a six-cent fee, and hence the creep *within* October: of 1,351 cafés checked twice that month, 15 per cent had raised at the first check and 22 per cent by the second.[1]

A letting agent cannot. The rent is a number in a lease. A strata levy is struck by an owners' corporation. Council rates are set by resolution. A tax liability is the tax liability. None of these can be lifted by one-and-a-half per cent to recover an acceptance cost, so the only lever available is to stop accepting the expensive instrument. That is why the withdrawals cluster exactly where pricing power is absent.



A *Meridian* figure. Café figures from a live price tracker read on 27 October against its own September prices; the fee is 1.3 per cent of a $5.09 cup, as one proprietor gave it. The withdrawals are each from the biller's own notice.

And the thing that was withdrawn was never really a discount. It was time. A card bought up to fifty-odd days of interest-free float on the largest and least deferrable payment in a household budget, and for a small business it bought the ability to pay a quarterly tax bill before the receivables landed. DEFT's own card fees were 0.40 per cent on debit and 1.50 on Visa credit; on rent of $700 a week that is $10.50 a week, $546 a year. Expensive — and what people were buying with it was not convenience but timing. The surcharge was the price of timing, and abolishing the price abolished the timing.[2]

The forums bear that out in the concrete way forums do. On an Australian bargain board the losses people name are specific: strata schemes with no alternative electronic option for which the rail was the only channel; renters who paid on a charge card and are migrating to third-party invoice services; owners who pre-paid body-corporate fees and rates on a card to reach a sign-up spend threshold or simply to buy interest-free weeks — one reports about 2,000 points on a $2,000 body-corporate payment. The practical fallback several of them name is standing at a post-office counter with a barcode.[3]

Which brings the argument to the uncomfortable part, and it is in the Reserve Bank's own document. Surcharges, it notes, were never in the Consumer Price Index: "consumers are already paying these costs via payment surcharges — which are not included in the Consumer Price Index." Folding them into sticker prices therefore adds about 0.1 percentage points to measured inflation — the bank's own estimate, which it calls small and one-off. It is small. It is also a cost the index could not previously see, inserted into the index by the institution that is tightening against it. Australian headline inflation ran 4.0 per cent in August and the cash rate was raised to 4.60 on 30 September, the fourth rise of the year.[3]

"Smoke can cross borders, so can money" was last week. This week: the fee crossed into the price, and the card crossed out.

SOURCES 1 The café price tracker, read at source on 27 October 2026; the within-month creep is its own repeated-check figure across 1,351 cafés. 2 DEFT's published card fees as a consumer-finance title listed them on 19 August 2026, read at source; the weekly and annual figures are that article's own arithmetic on $700 rent. The float characterisation is this desk's. 3 Two threads on an Australian consumer forum, opened 28 July and 20 August 2026 and read at source; posters are summarised rather than quoted where the point is collective. **Reddit refused this desk, so r/AusFinance and r/australia appear nowhere in this essay.** 4 The index's founder, quoted in a business title on 7 October 2026 and on his own tracker page, both read at source. **The competing transaction-based figure was reported second-hand by two outlets this desk could not read at source and is carried as unverified.** 5 Tax-office figures as a business title reported them on 1 October 2026; the commissioner's remark via a news agency, 9 October.

The honest objections are strong, and two of them come from the people whose numbers made the story.

The first is from the man who built the price index. He says plainly that cafés "have been getting hit by all of these price increases just like every business in Australia has", that the ban was a tipping point rather than a cause, and that his October figures are an early read. His own series supports him: the average smallest flat white had already climbed from $5.00 in April to $5.09 in September before the ban touched anything. His sample is also a telephone sample, which may over-represent the cafés that changed. A larger transaction-based dataset reportedly found only about one café in ten moving, and an average cup rising three or four cents — this desk could not read that release at source, and flags it as unverified rather than leaving it out.[1]

The second is the tax office's own arithmetic. Credit cards were only 2.3 per cent of tax payments in 2024–25, and about six in ten of those came from wealthy groups or major corporations. On that reading, withdrawing them removes a float and a points play for the well-advised rather than a lifeline for the corner shop — and the commissioner's other remark cuts the same way: funding the surcharge from the budget "would have the same ultimate outcome". The taxpayer pays either way.[2]

And 72 per cent of cafés did not move at all. Across every café in the sample the average rose six cents, which is the fee. On average, the consumer is square. The distribution is what is brutal, not the mean.

There is precedent for both halves, and it is unflattering. The same central bank created Australian surcharging in 2003 to send a price signal about expensive cards, and has now abolished it because merchants blended every card into one rate and the signal became noise. On whether the promised interchange savings reach merchants, its own survey of overseas experience is candid: in Britain after 2015 small and medium merchants got "little-to-no pass-through"; in the European Union only 45 per cent of the cut reached them, 45 staying in acquirer margins and 10 in scheme fees. New Zealand managed about 90. And at least 90 per cent of Australian merchants do not switch acquirer in a given year. The loss is immediate; the compensation is delayed, partial and historically leaky.[3]

A reform sold as making prices honest has instead measured, rather precisely, who is allowed to set one.

One more number ought to exist and does not. Surcharges sat outside the index; sticker prices sit inside it, so somebody must decide whether the transition counts as a price rise, a change of coverage or a quality adjustment. This desk could find no statement from the Australian Bureau of Statistics on how it will handle it — an absence that sits underneath every claim made about this reform, in either direction.[3]

What would prove this wrong. If the September and October inflation prints show no step in meals out, recreation or insurance beyond the bank's 0.1 point, the repricing was noise. If the transaction-level dataset holds and the telephone sample was biased, the eight-times figure collapses to an artefact. If acquirers pass the savings through at the New Zealand rate, the cafés will quietly unwind the fifty cents or competition will do it for them. And if the withdrawals reverse — the tax office's June 2027 deadline slips again, the rails switch cards back on — then this was a six-month transition, not a structural change. The first of those tests lands with today's print; the last with a deadline eight months out.[4]

What it reveals is not a scandal. It is a distribution. Transparency in payments turns out not to be a property of a rule but a function of pricing power: the party that can rewrite its own price treats a mandated fee as an opportunity, and the party that cannot treats it as a cost to be deleted along with the method that carried it. The fee is gone from every receipt in Australia. On one side of the economy it went into the price. On the other, the card went with it.

SOURCES 1 The index's founder, quoted in a business title on 3 Reserve Bank of Australia, *Conclusions Paper*, March 2026, pp.26 and 95 and its footnote 22, read at source; the inflation and cash-rate figures from the statistical agency's August release of 30 September and the bank's own cash-rate table. **The September print is published today and this page was set before it.** 4 The same paper's Box E on international pass-through and its account of the 2003 reforms; the falsification tests are this desk's.

THE LAST WORD

Who is allowed to set a price

A surcharge is an unusual object. It is a cost that has to announce itself. For twenty-three years Australia required one to appear on the receipt, on the theory that a consumer who can see what a card costs will choose a cheaper one. On the first of October that requirement ended, and the cost did what costs do when nobody is making them stand up and say their name.

Where somebody was free to rewrite a price, it went into the price, and then some: twenty per cent of cafés raised by an average of fifty-five cents against a fee of about six and a half (p21). Where nobody was free to rewrite a price — a rent in a lease, a levy struck by an owners' corporation, a tax liability — the card was simply switched off, and with it the fifty days of float that were the actual thing being bought.

Adam Smith's sentence on page two is usually quoted as a warning about cartels. It is better read as a remark about where prices come from: not from a rule, and not from a market in the abstract, but from whoever is in a position to write one down. This edition found the same asymmetry in quieter places — a prospectus that states its revenue to the dollar and its largest obligation as a blank (p7), a flagship headphone whose maker publishes everything except a distortion figure (p9), a watch on sale at six prices in one week (p10). None of it is a scandal. It is a distribution, and it is worth knowing which side of it you are standing on.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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SOURCES A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: a registration statement downloaded in full from the Securities and Exchange Commission's own archive and searched here; a central bank's conclusions paper and a commercial bank's own variation notice to its billers, both as filed; the United States Treasury's par and real yield curves, subtracted on this desk; a Singapore ministry's tripartite report, its text extracted and read; two papers at their journals in full, with their funding and competing-interest statements; a model card and two merge requests on a public code repository; makers' own storefronts in five currencies; and promoter, venue or organiser pages for every dated event on p19. Four figures in this issue are this magazine's own arithmetic and all four say so. Where a host refused us — Reddit for the thirteenth issue running, and so there is no Reddit sentiment anywhere in this book; Reuters, the Associated Press, the BBC, Bloomberg and Billboard; Israel's elections committee, whose portal serves nothing but a browser; Australia's tax office on every page; Audio-Technica for the third issue; Ilford, Photrio and the large-format forum; Heiland's own site; Hodinkee; Singapore's two main ticketing sites; and four parenting forums, which is why p12 carries no parent's voice — the page says so rather than quietly substituting. A correction to No. 145 runs on p8: the vLLM issue number we printed was wrong, and the real one is still open. Every photograph in this issue was opened and looked at before it was captioned.